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The Eight BIG CHANGES

The 26/11 attack may begin a militant transformation of India's political landscape

It has been famously said that a week is a long time in politics. Pare that down to three days, with a country with more than a billion people transfixed by gory wall-to-wall coverage of the carnage in its metropolis earlier known as Bombay and now Mumbai. The 62-hour stand-off between the terrorists and the commandos has rewritten the handwriting on the wall in red. What we have is what the Americans call a game-changer. In more ways than one.

The loss of close to 200 lives over the three long days of terror has had more impact on the public imagination than the more than 60,000 lives lost to terrorism over the past two decades.

THE MUMBAI ATTACK IS AN ASPECT OF GLOBALISATION INDIA HOPED TO BYPASS.

External bleeding is more visible than internal bleeding, although both can be equally life-threatening. This is change number one. So far it was by and large the nameless and faceless masses who had been the victims of terrorism but this time the brunt was also borne by the classes—the middle classes and beyond. The sequestered elite is no longer safe. This is change number two. When the Indian prime minister met the American President five years ago he could boast that India was home to more than 150 million Muslims but not to one Al Qaeda suspect. Now it has its own version of it—as global jihad overlaps with local jihad. This is change number three. Given the gradual rise in the profile of Islamic terrorism in India in preceding years, an attempt was recently made to identify

an incipient Hindu terrorism by “secular forces”, to establish a moral equivalence in India between the terrorism of the minority and the terrorism of the majority. The enormity of the present crisis overwhelms any such attempt. This is change number four. The events represent an aspect of globalisation the country had hoped to bypass but with this sanguinary reminder of the globalisation by other means, that honeymoon is over. The world is not only flat, it may be flattened. This is change number five. The bloodletting witnessed recently may also amount to a blood-transfusion for the BJP, whose current stand on terror stands fully vindicated (although its own past record in the matter remains somewhat suspect). This is change number six. The tragic events which engulfed the Jewish centre in Mumbai in the midst of this crisis, (in the course of which it became a liability to be a Jew in India for the first time), promise to convert the historical affinity between the two ancient “ethnic” entities—the Jews and the Hindus—into a Hinjew political accommodation. This is change number seven. That the perpetrators had Pakistani connections (though not necessarily with the Pakistan Government) threatens to freeze the thaw that had set in between the two countries, forcing them to revert to their old hostilities. This is change number eight.

Each of these changes is significant by itself, together they presage a militant transformation of the political landscape of India. Some centuries ago oppressive Mughal rule managed to transform a pacific Indian religious sect, known as the Sikhs, into a militant fraternity. Are the Hindus on the threshold of a similar transformation, under relentless pressure from the forces of aggressive Christian evangelical proselytisation and violent Jihadist terrorism? ■

I'M TIRED OF THE
SAAS BAHU SERIALS.

THE EXCUSES WILL STOP. AND
THE REASONS WILL BEGIN.
THANKS TO CREZENDO. WITH
THREE PREMIUM CONDOMS
AND A VIBRATING RING THAT
PROMISES TO TAKE YOUR
SEX LIFE TO NEW HEIGHTS.

